THE 15-MINUTE CHATS

— • —

eighty-six small conversations about everyday life

JAD

Beirut, Lebanon

The 15-Minute Chats

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This is a work of fiction. All characters and events in this book are fictional. Any resemblance to real people is coincidental, unless it made you laugh—in which case, it was probably on purpose.

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A Note on How This Book Was Made

Every conversation in this collection was written by the author. The manuscript was then organized into chapters, edited for spelling, grammar, and punctuation, and prepared for print with the help of Claude, an AI assistant made by Anthropic. Where two chats happened to share a character's name, one of them was given a new name so that every character in the book is their own person. The voice, the jokes, the randomness, and the people in these chats are entirely the author's own; the assistance was limited to structure, proofreading, and formatting.

A Note from the Author

This book is a series of chats between random people about everyday life: friends, siblings, couples, coworkers, parents and their kids, and the occasional stranger who walks in at exactly the wrong moment. They argue about football, haggle over how many children to have, plot their way out of awkward situations, and talk themselves in circles over almost nothing at all. Some of it is silly. Some of it is a little too honest. Some of it is just people being people, which, if you stop and really listen, is usually the funniest and most revealing thing of all. Characters with invented names show up throughout, and a few of these conversations might even make you raise an eyebrow or two. Bear with me—this is my first book, and my grammar, my wording, my tone… might come across as a bit judgmental in places. I promise that's not the point. The point is the talking itself: the back-and-forth, the misunderstandings, the jokes that land and the ones that don't, and the small moments when two people actually hear each other.

I'm twenty-four, a computer and communications engineer by training and a web developer by trade, but somewhere along the way I became someone who collects conversations the way other people collect coins or stamps. The weird ones, the amusing ones, the ones that are just plain interesting, and the ones that quietly teach you something about life without ever meaning to—I wanted to put them all in one place.

I grew up the way a lot of us did in the late nineties and early two-thousands: surrounded by people, always in the middle of one conversation or another, in person, face-to-face, no screens required. Somewhere between then and now, those interactions started thinning out. It got harder to strike up a conversation with certain people, harder

to just talk. This book is, in part, my answer to that—eighty-six small, imagined snapshots of people talking to each other, because I still believe there's nothing quite like it.

If there's one thing I care about more than most, it's putting a smile on someone's face, especially in the most unexpected, most awkward, most oddly specific situations. That's really what this whole collection is trying to do. I hope it puts a smile on yours, or at the very least, makes you wonder.

About This Book

The 15-Minute Chats is not a novel in the traditional sense. It doesn't follow one character from a beginning to an end, and it doesn't ask you to remember what happened three chapters ago. Instead, it's a collection of eighty-six short scenes—quick, self-contained conversations you could read in the time it takes to finish a coffee, or in exactly the time the title promises: about fifteen minutes, give or take, for whatever handful you pick up.

Each chapter drops you into the middle of a conversation already in motion: two friends arguing about football, a mother refusing to let her son play one more video game, a couple negotiating how many children they'll have, a young man trying to prove to his girlfriend's parents that he's worth trusting, a stranger asking someone whether they still remember how to talk instead of text. Some chapters are laugh-out-loud absurd. Others land somewhere quieter and more bittersweet. A few might sting a little, in the way that honest things sometimes do.

What ties them together isn't plot—it's the belief that ordinary conversation, in all its randomness, still has something worth paying attention to. These are fictional people having fictional conversations, but the situations, the awkward pauses, the running jokes, and the small moments of tenderness are drawn from a very real place: the everyday, messy, occasionally hilarious business of talking to other human beings.

Read it front to back, or open it anywhere and drop in. Either way works. That's kind of the whole idea.

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CHAPTER 1

Ask Me Out: The Male Version

———

Ali: You know what we should do?

Alice: What?

Ali: A new date idea.

Alice: Hmm…

Ali: No, seriously. If we want to get views on our vlogs, we should start thinking inside and outside the box.

Alice: Like asking me out in the middle of downtown, in front of everyone, and filming it?

Ali: Good thinking, but you do it to me, in front of everyone downtown, and we film it.

Alice: In that case, just ask me out now.

Ali: No, you ask me out. That's what I said.

Alice: I know, I know, but you do it first.

Ali: Okay? Would you go out with me?

Alice: No. But you could head downtown and see what I have in store for you.

Ali: Oh, you've got me on my toes with this one.

Alice: Indeed I do.

CHAPTER 2

Close the Door and Don't Say a Word

———

Celine: A new package came in the mail. Yara, is that for you?

Yara: Yes!

Celine: Did you pay for it, or did we pay for it?

Yara: Me!

Celine: Is it a new brush, or what?

Yara: A book. Look!

Celine: Close the door.

Yara: Why?

Celine: Close it, and don't talk.

Yara closes the door.

Celine: I know what you did. Buy another one of these and see what happens.

Yara: Huh?

The main door opens.

Celine opens the bedroom door.

Celine: Oh, hi! What are you doing here so early? We were just talking. Isn't that right, Yara?

Yara: Yes!

CHAPTER 3

Just Say My Name

———

Jack: We've been friends for a while, and you still haven't said my name right.

Omar: It's Jack.

Jack: No.

Omar: Jackson.

Jack: Close, but no.

Omar: Jack the Man?

Jack: Just say my name.

Omar: Batman.

Jack: Closer.

Omar: Green Lantern?

Jack: No!

Omar: What are you, then?

Jack: I'll make you laugh, but all I want is to watch the world burn.

Omar: The Joker?

Jack: Harley Quinn.

Omar: Ha-ha. Good one.

Jack: See…

Jack: Am I not amusing?

Omar: Yes, you are that. Totally that.

CHAPTER 4

Send Me an Email

———

Hazem: I bought a ticket back home, but I need to stay in touch with my professor, so I'm heading over to his office right now.

Sally: You know he doesn't care about you. You know that.

Hazem: Whether he cares or not, I want to talk to him. Just to stay in touch.

Sally: Suit yourself.

Hazem: Just wait by the door while I talk to him.

Sally: Sure.

Hazem opens the door to his professor's office.

Professor Xavier: Send me an email and have a fun break.

Hazem: But you don't even know what I was going to say.

Professor Xavier: Send me an email. I'd be delighted to read it. Now go; I'm busy.

Hazem: Okay, sir. Sorry, sir.

Sally: So? What did he say?

Hazem: "Send me an email."

CHAPTER 5

Shake My Hand

———

The doorbell rings.

Mr. Jeffery: Open the door. The boy is here.

Mrs. Jeffery: I'll open it.

Sara: Me too!

The door opens.

Mohammed enters.

Mr. Jeffery: So, you're the boy.

Mohammed: Indeed I am.

Mr. Jeffery: What do you do?

Mohammed: I'm a real estate agent, sir. I have a car, a Honda, and I own an apartment twenty minutes' drive from here. I'm still paying off the apartment, but I only have a couple of months left.

Mr. Jeffery: Well, isn't that fascinating, Mrs. Jeffery?

Mrs. Jeffery: Yes, it is.

Mohammed: I forgot to introduce myself, sir. My name is Mohammed.

Mr. Jeffery: Well, in that case, shake my hand.

Mohammed: Shake your hand?

Mr. Jeffery: Shake my hand. Yes.

CHAPTER 6

I Am the One Getting Married, Not You

———

Alia: It's my big day.

Dona: Yes, it is.

Alia: I want everything to be perfect.

Dona: And I'll make sure that happens.

Alia: First, my dress.

Dona: Well, before we put on the dress: do you want white flowers or pink ones for the ceremony? I'm thinking white, or do you prefer white yourself? What do you think is best?

Alia: Ugh! I'm the one getting married, not you.

Dona: White it is. You'll make a great wife.

Alia: Yes, I will. And now, the dress.

Dona: Right on, right on.

CHAPTER 7

Be the Change

———

Fadi: Got any cigars?

Fadia: No?

Viktor: I've got some back at my place.

Fadi: Too far. Let's buy some from the store downstairs.

Fadia: Buy what? Cigars?

Fadi: Yes.

Viktor: I'm down.

Fadia: You're both psychos. I'm leaving.

Fadi: Whatever.

Viktor: What are you going to do? Head to the gym?

Fadia: Better.

Viktor: What?

Fadia: Cycle my way out of here.

Viktor: It's two in the morning.

Fadia: Who cares?

Fadi: And that is why you're my twin sister.

CHAPTER 8

Read Between the Lines

———

Henry: I bought a scooter.

Firas: I bought a bike.

Rami's Dad: What does that mean, Rami?

Rami: That I might get a bike, or a scooter, or even better, a car.

Rami's Dad: No. It means they'll let you borrow their scooters and bikes until your dad can afford to buy you one of your own.

Henry: We sure will, sir.

Firas: Yes, indeed.

Rami: But, Dad, I want my own.

Rami's Dad: Until next time, my boy. Until next time.

CHAPTER 9

A Mental Breakdown

———

Gloria: Her boyfriend is my ex.

Patricia: Are you sure?

Gloria: Yes.

Patricia: So you and he were a thing?

Gloria: Yes.

Patricia: Wow. Wow.

Gloria: What do I do? I can't see him, and I can't see her. She's like a sister to me.

Patricia: She's your best friend. Now get out of the bathroom; you're only making it worse.

Gloria: I can't. I can't! I still love him!

Patricia: Take deep breaths and take it slowly. You have your own boyfriend.

Gloria: Bite me!

Patricia: Get out, now!

Gloria: I will! Now leave me alone so I can get out in peace!

Patricia: I will.

CHAPTER 10

Sing Me a Song

———

Richard: I've walked this path more times than I can remember.

Emily: It's my first time.

Richard: That's true.

Emily: What do you do?

Richard: What do I do… what?

Emily: Other than walking, what do you do? While walking, I mean.

Richard: Well, I sing.

Emily: Well, in that case, sing me a song.

Richard: Do you sing?

Emily: Sometimes, yes.

Richard: Then I want to hear you first.

Emily: No, it's common courtesy for you to go first. Besides, what else do you do, other than singing?

Richard: Talk to ChatGPT.

Emily: ChatGPT? Really?

Richard: Yes, and it says I should sing "My Way."

Emily: Well, go ahead.

Richard: Here it comes, my lady.

Emily: I'm all ears.

CHAPTER 11

Take It or Leave It

———

Kenan: I want to buy this book, but it's way out of my budget.

William: You can read it online for free.

Kenan: I like having the actual book, okay?

Cashier: Are you buying the book or not?

William: Fine, I'll pay for it. You'll thank me later.

Kenan: No, wait, I can pay. I'll use my credit card.

William: Go ahead.

Kenan tries to pay.

Cashier: Declined. Take it or leave it, kid. Do you want your friend to pay or not?

Kenan: I'll leave it.

William: Are you sure?

Kenan: Yes.

William: Good call, because I didn't have the money.

CHAPTER 12

Get Dressed, We're Leaving, Because She Started It

———

Peter: Frank, we need to talk.

Frank: What?

Peter: Your wife is out of hand with my wife, and we need to leave.

Frank: Why?

Peter: For starters, she started it.

Frank: Well, we could both still be friends.

Peter: I guess so. But there's a lot to be gained if we aren't.

Frank: I don't follow.

Peter: Makeup sex later.

Frank: Oh. Well, you have a point.

Peter: See?

Frank: Enemies for now.

Peter: Enemies for now.

CHAPTER 13

A Couple Who Love Each Other

———

Suzan: You know what we should buy?

Saeed: What?

Suzan: Weights.

Saeed: Why?

Suzan: To get in shape, you know.

Saeed: But we already have a gym membership.

Suzan: Oh, right. That.

Saeed: Anyway, do you want some honey?

Suzan: But you're diabetic.

Saeed: It's healthy sugar.

Suzan: Next time.

A silent moment.

Saeed: Do you think we're a great couple?

Suzan: The best.

Saeed: No, really?

Suzan: I think we're trying our best, and in a sense, it's working out.

Saeed: Well, we'll keep on trying.

Suzan: Yes, we will.

Saeed: So, honey it is, then?

Suzan: Still a no, my dear.

Saeed: Love is surely in the air.

Suzan: Oh, yes, it is, my dear.

CHAPTER 14

Two Geniuses

———

Nader: I know it's difficult, but you have to trust me on this one.

Lama: Do it. I trust you.

Nader: One, two…

Lama: Did it work?

Nader: Start the engine.

Lama starts the engine.

Lama: It worked!

Nader: Where do you want to go?

Lama: Home, I guess.

Nader: But what about our plans?

Lama: Going to the other side of town? No, thank you.

Nader: Not the other side of town. Somewhere far. That's what we talked about.

Lama: Next time. Yeah, next time.

Nader: Look, the cops!

Lama: Oh, shoot! Got to go. Bye!

Nader: Turn it off!

Lama: You're right.

Lama turns off the engine.

The cops pass by.

Nader: What now?

Lama: It won't start again.

Nader: I wonder why.

Lama: Because I don't want to go somewhere far away with you? You jerk.

Nader: No, because you're turning it wrong. Here, do it like this.

The engine starts.

Lama: Cool! Now bye, loser.

Nader talks to himself.

Nader: Somewhere far, far, far away…

The engine roars.

Nader: Far, far away.

CHAPTER 15

Who Will Win?

———

Fouad: The game is still going.

Tammy: Really?

Fouad: They'll go to penalties. That's what I think.

Tammy: So? Who do you think is going to win?

Fouad: By the looks of it, the guys in white stripes have the upper hand.

Tammy: But?

Fouad: But I'm betting on the guys wearing purple.

Tammy: Who's wearing purple?

Fouad: You?

Tammy: Well, I'm not a guy.

Fouad: Oh, I know. But you sure sound like one when you talk about football.

Tammy: Stop it.

Fouad: The ones in blue are the ones I'm betting on, by the way.

Tammy: Good to know. Now, good luck.

Fouad: Thank you!

CHAPTER 16

We Lost

———

Daniel: It's over. It's all over!

Pamela: What's over?

Daniel: Like you don't know what I'm talking about.

Pamela: You mean the game?

Daniel: Yes, the game!

Pamela: You've got to stay hopeful.

Daniel: What does that mean?

Pamela: My nanny used to say that God will open a way for you as long as you're hopeful and faithful.

A moment of silence.

Pamela: It's an old saying. If you don't want to believe it, that's fine. Just remember that there's light at the end of the tunnel. Okay?

Daniel: BUT WE LOST!

Pamela: Oh, I know, dear, and I'm as sad as you are. Now get ready; we have to go.

Daniel: Okay. But we lost. Okay?

Pamela: Yes, we did.

CHAPTER 17

Do You Know Any Spells?

———

Gordon: What are you planning to go as for Halloween?

Youssef: Halloween isn't for another four months.

Gordon: Do you at least have an idea of what you're going as?

Youssef: Maybe a wizard. I don't know.

Gordon: Do you know any spells?

Youssef: None that I know of. No.

Gordon: Well, you'd better start learning.

Gordon hands Youssef a stick.

Gordon: Say "Lumos."

Youssef: Lumos.

The lights turn on.

Gordon: Oh my God, you're a wizard, Youssef!

Youssef: Yes, I am. Halloween, here I come!

Gordon: Well, don't try the Avada one, or you'll kill us all.

Youssef: Sure thing.

CHAPTER 18

Explain It in Numbers

———

Lea: It's over.

Nour: No, it's not.

Lea: It is.

Nour: Explain!

Lea: Seven, eight, nine.

Nour: That doesn't make sense.

Lea: Seven-eight-nine.

Nour: What?

Lea: I'll repeat it.

Nour: I'm listening.

Lea: Seven… eight… nine.

Nour: Again.

Lea: Okay. Seven… eight… nine.

Nour: Now I get it.

Lea: You do?

Nour: Seven, eight, nine.

Lea: Seven, eight, nine.

Nour: That's it?

Lea: Yeah. As simple as it sounds.

Nour: As simple as it sounds, indeed.

CHAPTER 19

Complete the Sentence

———

George: When I go to the bathroom, I either brush my hair or shave my…?

Kids in Class: Beard!

George: Good job!

Silence.

George: If I eat less, I lose…?

Kids in Class: Weight!

George: Correct!

Silence.

George: I type my email on my…?

Kids in Class: Laptop?

George: Incorrect. You type on your keyboard. It's part of your laptop and your phone. Anyway, good job, class, and good luck on your exam next week.

CHAPTER 20

Get Motivated

———

Carlos: The gym is important.

Stephanie: Why?

Carlos: To build muscle, to be healthy, to lose weight…

Stephanie: I've gained weight since I started going to the gym.

Carlos: It's just a saying that it makes you lose weight. It's not always true.

Stephanie: Then the gym isn't that important.

Carlos: It is. With the right diet, it is.

Stephanie: Will you live longer?

Carlos: Yes, sure. Why not?

Stephanie: Prove it.

Carlos: There are a lot of studies that prove it, and you can go ahead and check them out.

Stephanie: Okay. I'm still not convinced.

Carlos: Look, it's either "one day" or "day one."

Stephanie: Dwayne Johnson style.

Carlos: Yes, sure, why not? One day, or day one.

Stephanie: Fair.

CHAPTER 21

Hashtag

———

Younes: What are the right tags to add if I post this hangout?

Clara: You mean hashtags?

Younes: Yes, hashtags. I want to make it memorable.

Clara: People don't care about hashtags anymore, but I can give you a list I found online.

Younes: Is it good?

Clara: It has all the hashtags that are worthwhile and trendy. You just have to copy and paste.

Younes: Well, send it over.

Clara: But remember, it's not in the hashtags. There's more to it.

Younes: It's the thought that counts.

Clara: It's the thought that counts. Yes, it is.

CHAPTER 22

Buttercup

———

Freddy: You know what feels right?

Eddie: What?

Freddy: Eating dessert.

Eddie: What kind?

Freddy: Something with butter.

Eddie: A buttercup?

Freddy: Yes, sure. Why not?

Eddie: But that's what Mom calls me.

Freddy: Then I'll have you for dessert.

Eddie: Really?

Freddy: Just move along. I'm only kidding.

Eddie: That wasn't funny.

Freddy: It was for me. Now, let's cross the street.

Eddie: Sure.

CHAPTER 23

Do the Math

———

Tommy: We won fair and square.

Shadi: Not really.

Tommy: How so?

Shadi: Do the math. Who scored more goals?

Tommy: But they're cheaters.

Shadi: Math doesn't lie, my friend.

Tommy: Yes, it does, when you're cheating.

Shadi: It's the language of the universe. It doesn't lie, my friend.

Tommy: Are you leaving?

Shadi leaves.

Shadi: Just remember: it doesn't lie!

Tommy screams after him.

Tommy: Beat it!

Shadi screams back.

Shadi: Doesn't lie!

CHAPTER 24

How Are You?

———

Randa: I'm going to the mall. I'll be there in five minutes.

Amy: How are you?

Randa: I'm fine. I just need to get in my car and get to the mall.

Amy: But I miss you. Let's chat for a bit.

Randa: Got to go. Bye.

Amy touches Randa's hand.

Amy: Don't be late, okay?

Randa: Sure?

Silence.

Randa: Now, bye.

Randa gets into her car.

Randa: Weird.

CHAPTER 25

Too Much

———

Wael: I want to have five children with you.

Jessica: Too many.

Wael: What about three?

Jessica: Too many as well.

Wael: Two?

Jessica: What about none?

Wael: We can't live like this.

Jessica: Yes, we can.

Wael: It's too much.

Jessica: You're right. It is.

Wael: One it is, then?

Jessica: One it is.

Wael: There's a chance we might have twins, by the way.

Jessica: One it is, my dear.

Wael: One it is.

CHAPTER 26

Don't Chase Him

———

Walter: I've been in your shoes.

Rosa: Really?

Walter: Just ignore him. He'll come around.

Rosa: Really?

Walter: As a wise man once told me, don't chase butterflies. They'll only fly away.

Rosa: What do I do instead?

Walter: Build a beautiful garden.

Rosa: And?

Walter: And the butterflies will come.

Silence.

Rosa: And if they don't come?

Walter: You still have a beautiful garden.

Rosa: Yes, I do.

CHAPTER 27

It's Actually True

———

Tyler: What did he say about me?

Barney: Nothing important.

Tyler: What?

Barney: That you're into movies.

Tyler: What kind of movies?

Barney: Sexy, heroic, erotic movies.

Tyler: I'm not.

Barney: He said he filmed you.

Tyler: Good.

Barney: So it's true?

Tyler: Partially, yes.

Barney: Such a weirdo.

Tyler: Just keep it a secret, okay?

Barney: Sure. Why not?

Tyler: Thanks!

CHAPTER 28

Someone Is Gone

———

Oscar: Where did he go?

David: Oh, he's gone.

Oscar: Tell me!

David: Gone, and he'll never come back.

Oscar: Tell me! Where is he?

David: Look out the window.

Oscar looks out the window.

David pushes Oscar out the window.

David: Gone, and he'll never come back.

CHAPTER 29

You Answer to Me

———

Zahraa: Why are all the files wrong?

Katie: The manager told me to organize them this way.

Zahraa: Well, I'm the boss, and you answer to me. You organize the files in alphabetical order. Got it?

Katie: I spent a lot of time…

Zahraa: Alphabetical. Got it?

Katie nods.

Zahraa: Good. Now get back to work.

Silence.

Zahraa: Everybody, get back to work!

CHAPTER 30

Details, I Need More Details

———

Lydia: Get it checked.

Indela: Get what checked?

Lydia: The you-know-what.

Indela: I can't understand you.

Lydia: The thing…

Indela: I need more details!

Lydia: Okay, but not here.

Indela: Where, then?

Lydia: In the thing that needs to be checked.

Indela: My car?

Lydia: Close. Now follow me.

Indela: This doesn't feel right.

Lydia: Trust me, it will. Just move along.

Indela: Fine.

Lydia: Fine!

CHAPTER 31

Don't Be Late

———

Sandra: Think of it this way.

Camila: How?

Sandra: You go out with him, then I go out with him, and then we both win.

Camila: What?

Sandra: It's simple. You get to forget all about your boyfriend, and I get the chance to be with him.

Camila: But that doesn't feel right.

Sandra: Think of it this way: both of us win, with money, love, and friendship.

Camila: I'm not sure about that.

Sandra: Either way, I love you, dear Camila.

Camila: I'm going to the bathroom, and I might never come back.

Sandra: Don't be late.

Camila: You bet I won't.

CHAPTER 32

Don't Take These

———

Cassandra: I want to try them.

Baren: No!

Cassandra: Come on.

Baren: No means no.

Cassandra: Like you've never tried any of them.

Baren: I have, but I'm not addicted to them. Unlike you.

Cassandra: Only one.

Baren: No!

Cassandra: Only one. Please…

Baren slaps Cassandra.

Cassandra: Hey! You didn't have to do that!

Baren: As I said, and I'll say it calmly this time: no means no.

Cassandra: Okay…

Baren: Good.

CHAPTER 33

Risk It

———

Jackson: I've lost everything, and I still have one bet to make.

Natalie: Risk it.

Jackson: What?

Natalie: If you only have one bet to make, risk everything.

Jackson: That's what I'm doing, isn't it?

Natalie: I said everything.

Jackson: I don't follow.

Natalie: If you only have one bet to make, risk everything. Me included.

Jackson: Are you sure?

Natalie nods and whispers.

Natalie: Everything…

CHAPTER 34

Buy Me a Drink

———

Andros: I'm your friend.

Doha: Yes?

Andros: And you've never bought me a drink.

Doha: What?

Andros: Buy me a drink, my friend.

Doha: What are you, my girlfriend?

Andros: Better.

Doha: What?

Andros: Your childhood best friend.

Doha: I've only known you for a year.

Andros: But it feels like forever.

Doha: Piss off.

Andros: Are you buying me a drink or not?

Doha: Like I said, piss off.

Andros: Got it.

CHAPTER 35

Focus

———

Hanna: We need a better system.

Mary: What do you mean?

Hanna: I mean we need to start over.

Mary: Focus. Look at it differently.

Hanna: How?

Mary: This way…

Hanna: Hmm?

Mary: See?

Hanna: I still don't get it.

Mary: Look closely. You'll see it now.

Hanna: I'll try. Oh!

Mary: Got it.

CHAPTER 36

Don't Break Eye Contact

———

Mark: Watch closely.

Stacey: One, two, and three?

Mark: Yes! Good. Repeat.

Stacey: One, two, three…

Mark: Wait, wait, wait…

Stacey: What?

Mark: Look at me, okay?

Stacey: Okay. One, two, and three…

Mark: Wrong. Wrong.

Stacey: What?

Mark: Don't break eye contact.

Stacey: Sure thing.

Mark: Again.

Stacey: One, two, and three…

Mark: Good. Keep it up. You've got this.

Stacey: Sure. Thanks.

Mark: You're welcome.

CHAPTER 37

Talk to Me

———

Ernestine: Tell me, what's the probability of this function?

Verdun: I think I'm going out, Mom.

Ernestine: Verdun, tell me: what's the probability of this function?

Verdun: Mom, don't forget!

Ernestine: Talk to me, Verdun. Talk to me.

Verdun: Okay, Mom!

Ernestine: Verdun?

Verdun: Thanks, Mom.

Ernestine: Verdun, answer me.

Verdun: Bye!

Ernestine: Verdun!

CHAPTER 38

Sure Thing

———

Grace: I want a dress.

Hussam: Sure.

Grace: And a mansion.

Hussam: Sure.

Grace: Near the lake.

Hussam: Sure.

Grace: And I want children. A lot of children.

Hussam: Sure…

Grace: What do you want?

Hussam: You.

Grace: That's it?

Hussam: Yes!

Grace: No money, no family, no prosperity?

Hussam: Just you.

Grace: You're lying.

Hussam: No, I'm not.

Grace: Good.

Hussam: Good.

CHAPTER 39

I Bought a New Phone

———

Kevin: Which one do you want?

Stewart: This one.

Kevin: Are you sure?

Stewart: I am.

Kevin: Too expensive. Choose another one.

Stewart: What about this one?

Kevin: Are you sure?

Stewart: What about this one?

Kevin: The other one is better.

Stewart: Sure.

Kevin: You know, once we buy this, there's no going back.

Stewart: Fine by me.

Kevin: Okay. So you're going to buy a new phone.

Stewart: Yes, I am.

Kevin: As the Arabs say, "Mabrouk!"

Stewart: "Mabrouk" it is.

Kevin: Good.

Stewart: I bought a new phone.

CHAPTER 40

Hit Me

———

Nicolas: Flip a coin.

Brad: Why?

Nicolas: Just flip it.

Brad: What's your call?

Nicolas: Tails.

Brad flips the coin.

Brad: It's heads.

Nicolas: Good.

Brad: What now?

Nicolas: Hit me.

Brad: Why?

Nicolas: I lost the bet.

Brad: I'm not going to hit you.

Nicolas: Just hit me. Come on.

Brad: Not today.

Nicolas: Tomorrow?

Brad: Never. Now let's go.

Nicolas: Tomorrow it is, then.

Brad: Tomorrow it is.

CHAPTER 41

Release All the Videos

———

Owen: What do you know about him?

Xi: That he has these videos.

Owen: Release them.

Xi: But that isn't right.

Owen: Don't tell me what's right and what's wrong.

Xi: These videos are dangerous to the public.

Owen: Will they hurt anyone?

Xi: Not directly, no.

Owen: Then release them. You have my consent.

Xi: There's no going back from this.

Owen: I know, and I take responsibility.

Xi: Suit yourself.

Owen: Will they get publicity?

Xi: Yes, they will.

Owen: Good. Good.

CHAPTER 42

Try Me

———

Gerrard: You can't jump this high.

Lewis: Are you sure?

Gerrard: Pretty sure.

Lewis: I've done it before.

Gerrard: No, you haven't.

Lewis: I have proof.

Gerrard: Then jump, now.

Lewis: I will.

Gerrard: I'm waiting.

Lewis jumps.

Gerrard whispers.

Gerrard: He actually did it.

Lewis: Told you so!

CHAPTER 43

Make It Even

———

Viktoria: I ended the debate.

Jefferson: Which debate?

Viktoria: The one between me and my boyfriend.

Jefferson: Make it right.

Viktoria: What do you mean?

Jefferson: Call it even.

Viktoria: That easily?

Jefferson: There's nothing wrong with that.

Viktoria: But I won.

Jefferson: He's your boyfriend.

Viktoria: And?

Jefferson: And sacrifices have to be made.

Viktoria: Like calling it even?

Jefferson: In the right situations, yes.

CHAPTER 44

This Will Never End

———

Ahmed: One last game, Mom.

Claudia: No more games!

Ahmed: I've been practicing, and I'll win this time.

Claudia: That's what you said last time.

Ahmed: Did they name you Claudia after Claude, the AI, Mom?

Claudia: Funny. Now go to your room.

Ahmed: I need to play, Mom.

Claudia: When you get a break. Okay?

Ahmed: I have a break right now.

Claudia: You have a punishment. Now deal with it, and sit in your room.

Ahmed: That easily?

Claudia: Yes!

Ahmed: Do you know that I love you, Mom?

Claudia: Bite me, and go to your room.

Ahmed: I hate you, Mom.

Claudia: I hate you too!

CHAPTER 45

Clear Your Mind

———

Nathan: We're trying a new sport.

Tracey: What is it?

Nathan: You'll find out. Now, follow me.

Tracey: Come on, tell me. What is it?

Nathan: Okay, okay. It's yoga.

Tracey: Not for me.

Nathan: Why?

Tracey: I'm too active.

Nathan: What do you want, then?

Tracey: To lift weights.

Nathan: Then we'll do yoga and then lift weights. Does that sound good to you?

Tracey: Not really.

Nathan: What do you want?

Tracey: Weights, I guess.

Nathan: Okay, okay. Weights it is.

Tracey: No yoga?

Nathan: No yoga.

CHAPTER 46

Be the One

———

Fares: I need to change my room.

Zeinab: What do you want to change about it?

Fares: I want to add a bookshelf.

Zeinab: Nice, nice. That sounds interesting.

Fares: And a new carpet. Not much, just a little change here and there.

Zeinab: What do you think about my room?

Zeinab shows Fares a picture of her room.

Fares: Seems quite interesting. It's amazing as it is.

Zeinab: Are you sure? Not a bookshelf, or a carpet?

Fares: Nothing. It's perfect as it is.

Zeinab: Really?

Fares: Like its owner.

Zeinab: Really?

Fares: Like your dad, I mean. Not you.

Zeinab: Nice one. Nice. Really nice.

Fares: It sure is.

CHAPTER 47

The Long Wait in Line

———

Johnny: I need at least two hours to get to the front of the line.

Mahmoud: Well, you have to wait.

Johnny: What if I have to go to the bathroom?

Mahmoud: Well, you pee your pants.

Johnny: But I can't wait this long.

Mahmoud: Stop whining and start getting ready instead.

Johnny: Sure.

Mahmoud: Now, one last question.

Johnny: What?

Mahmoud: Do you need to go to the bathroom?

Johnny: No, not yet.

Mahmoud: Good, good. That's good.

Johnny: Do you need to go to the bathroom?

Mahmoud: What does this have to do with me? Thanks for asking, but no.

Johnny: Just checking.

Mahmoud: Okay!

CHAPTER 48

Red Stripes

———

Jennifer: What color is your new jacket?

Megan: Light blue.

Jennifer: Mine is red.

Megan: All red?

Jennifer: All red.

Megan: Why don't you get this one?

Megan shows Jennifer a picture of a jacket.

Jennifer: Not my style.

Megan: This is what's trending, Jenny.

Jennifer: No. Besides, I like it this way. It brings out the color of my eyes.

Megan: Jenny, look. The more old-fashioned you are, the more people frown at you.

Jennifer: But I like it.

Megan: The faster you change, the better.

Jennifer: Leave me alone!

Megan: Bye!

CHAPTER 49

Move Out

———

Don: My life is going my way.

Gavin: How so?

Don: I have a job, a car, a girlfriend… everything.

Gavin: But there's something missing.

Don: And?

Gavin: You tell me.

Don: Well, I still live at my parents' place.

Gavin: And?

Don: And what? I'm still doing better than you.

Gavin: I know, but to excel, you still have to…

Don: To…

Gavin: Move out.

Don: You think that's best?

Gavin: I'm sure of it.

Don: Well, I'll consider it.

CHAPTER 50

Tell Us a Tale

———

Widad: Dad, I like your stories.

Adel: Which stories?

Widad: The stories you used to tell us when we were young.

Adel: Oh, those stories. Well, I still have a lot I haven't told.

Widad: Then tell us one.

Adel: It's simple. Okay, the story goes like this. It started when I was nine years old and met Mr. Dunkin.

Widad: Who's Mr. Dunkin?

Adel: An old pal of mine. Now, do you want me to tell the story or not?

Widad: Wait, wait, I want another one. I want the one about you in Turkey.

Adel: The one where I got robbed, or the one where I got lost?

Widad: Aren't they the same?

Adel: As I recall, they are the same.

Widad: Well, tell me the tale of Dad in Turkey.

Adel: You have a deal…

CHAPTER 51

I Am Angry

———

Paul: What's wrong?

Ottman: EVERYTHING!

Paul: No, really?

Ottman: LIKE I TOLD YOU. EVERYTHING!

Paul: Even your health?

Ottman: My blood sugar is through the roof. What do you think?

Paul: Your financial situation?

Ottman: EVEN MY FINANCIAL SITUATION!

Paul: Okay, okay. You don't have to scream every single word.

Ottman: I AM ANGRY! WHAT DO YOU THINK IS WRONG WITH ME?

Paul: Hormones? I don't know what you're taking. Calm down, jeez.

Ottman: Why not? Okay, I'll try. You're right.

Paul: Good. Now focus; we have plans.

Ottman: FUCK YOU AND YOUR PLANS!

Ottman leaves.

Paul: Hey, wait up!

CHAPTER 52

Have You Met Anyone Like Me Before?

———

Abby: I like your bag.

Adela: Thanks! I bought it myself.

Abby: I like how it matches your heels.

Adela: Does it?

Abby: Yes, totally.

Adela: What courses are you taking this semester?

Abby: Arabic and chemistry.

Adela: What about graphic design?

Abby: What about it?

Adela: Isn't it your thing?

Abby: I want to become a doctor.

Adela: But you come from a fashion background. Don't you want to follow in your mom's footsteps?

Abby: I want to save the world.

Adela: That easily?

Abby: Yes!

Adela: Wow!

CHAPTER 53

Bring It Back

———

Ronald: Wait!

Kyle: What?

Ronald: You have something for me.

Kyle: You mean this?

Ronald: No! Something else.

Kyle: I don't know what you're talking about, man.

Ronald: The… the…

Kyle: The what? I have to leave.

Ronald: Hey! I want it back.

Kyle: I'm leaving.

Ronald: Hey!

CHAPTER 54

I Love You

———

Randy: You know what, Fingernail?

Fingernail: Woof.

Randy: Even though you're a dog, I'll always know for a fact that you love me.

Fingernail: Woof, woof.

Randy: Even though I'm broke and living in a van, I know for a fact that I love you. And you love me, and that's all we need. Isn't that right, Fingernail?

Fingernail: Woof, woof, woof.

Randy: You've gotten me a lot of dates with girls, and now it's your time to shine, by getting me back together with this one girl. Do you trust me to nail this one, Fingernail? Because I trust you.

Fingernail: Woof.

Randy: Yeah, yeah, I know. Too cheesy. But we've got to try. There's no shame in trying, and a lot of regret in not trying. You get me, boy?

Fingernail: Woof.

Randy: Oh, I love you, boy.

Fingernail: WOOF!

CHAPTER 55

I Hate You

———

Joey: Explain to the man what he did to you.

Lily: Nothing.

Travis: See? Nothing. I told you, Officer, it was a big misunderstanding.

Joey: Come on, Lily. You were playing in the playground, then you went to the bathroom, and then?

Travis: And then nothing happened. I came and got her out of the bathroom. End of story.

Joey: Come on, Lily, just tell the police officer what happened, okay?

Lily looks at Travis.

Lily: I hate you!

Joey: That's a sign. Now tell the officer. Come on, Lily.

Lily looks at Travis again.

Lily: I hate you!

CHAPTER 56

Break It Apart

———

Martin: I hate this car.

Jerry: You don't hate it. You just don't know how to use it.

Martin: It's not working!

Jerry: Then get it checked. You'll find out what's wrong with it.

Martin: Really?

Jerry: Really! Once you get it fixed, you can drive it all over town. It'll be the smoothest ride of your life.

Martin: I don't trust this car, you know.

Jerry: Why not?

Martin: It's not a smooth ride for me. I got a stomachache the last time I got in it.

Jerry: Just trust the process, and you'll enjoy it.

Martin: Are you sure?

Jerry: Totally.

CHAPTER 57

End the Conversation. Now.

———

Monica: I'm talking to my sister. What do you want?

Molly: That's not your sister.

Monica: How so?

Molly: I'm sure of it!

Monica: Well, it's her voice.

Molly ends the call.

Monica: Hey! That was rude!

Molly: It's a bot.

Monica: It's a what?

Molly: It's an AI.

Monica: Really? But it sounded so real.

Molly: I bet it did.

CHAPTER 58

Get It Out of Your System

———

Joffrey: I like you, Sofia.

Sofia: Me too.

Joffrey: Let's get married.

Sofia: Tomorrow, perhaps?

Joffrey: Tomorrow it is. We'll have the greatest wedding, and everyone will talk about it.

Sofia: You're forgetting something, my dear.

Joffrey: And what's that?

Sofia: The apple, my dear love. Your apple.

Joffrey: Yes, the apple.

Joffrey eats the apple.

Joffrey chokes.

Sofia: Never forget your apple, my dear prince.

CHAPTER 59

Furious

———

Zoey: There's this movie about cars.

Vanessa: Which one?

Zoey: Fast cars and racing.

Vanessa: Cartoon or real life?

Zoey: Real life, and cars.

Vanessa: And cars…

Zoey: Yes! It's Fast…

Vanessa: Fast and…

Zoey: Fast and…

Vanessa: I still don't remember.

Zoey: It's a double F.

Vanessa: F for failure?

Zoey: No, not The Fast and the Failure.

Vanessa: Something better and closer, I think, isn't it?

Zoey: Yes! What's another word for angry?

Vanessa: Furious?

Zoey: Yes! Yes! The Fast and the Furious!

Vanessa: Oh, right. I knew that.

Zoey: Furious. Thank you!

Vanessa: Anytime!

CHAPTER 60

Just Love Me

———

Rachel: Let's go out.

Kamel: Today?

Rachel: Yes!

Kamel: But I thought you had something planned.

Rachel: Like what?

Kamel: Like staying home and, you know…

Rachel: You know, what?

Kamel: You know. Mingle a bit.

Rachel: Next time! Now, let's go out.

Kamel: What, you don't love me?

Rachel: I love you, but I need to buy these new shoes. So… we need to go out.

Kamel: I'm not buying you anything until we fool around.

Rachel: Stop acting like a baby, and let's go…

Kamel: But…

Rachel: Let's go!

CHAPTER 61

Draw Me Instead

———

Billal: You're such an artist, my friend.

Harry: I've never seen a drawing like it in my life.

Billal: You've drawn me perfectly, my friend.

Harry: I want you to draw me now.

Billal: No, me again. We had a deal.

Sami: I'll draw both of you together, as friends. Does that sound right?

Harry: Fine by me.

Billal: But after this drawing, I want a painting of my own.

Harry: Me too.

Sami: Sure! Three paintings…

Harry: But me first.

Billal: No! Me first.

CHAPTER 62

Main Gate

———

Theresia: What a day!

Theresa: What a party!

Theresia: Did you see how everything happened at once at the end?

Theresa: Yeah!

Theresia: Oh my God, such a dramatic scene.

Theresa: Yeah!

Theresia: Anyway, where are you heading?

Theresa: Home.

Theresia: I meant, which way are you leaving?

Theresa: Oh, through the main gate, I think.

Theresia: Don't!

Theresa: Why?

Theresia: Follow me instead.

Theresa: What? Why?

Theresia: Just do as I say, and everything will go smoothly.

Theresa: What? Theresia!

Theresia: Just move along. Don't you trust me?

Theresa: I mean, yeah.

Theresia: Then let's go.

CHAPTER 63

Flowers Are a Good Idea

———

Dana: You know what I want?

Salim: What?

Dana: Guess.

Salim: Chocolate?

Dana: No.

Salim: A book?

Dana: No!

Salim: A horse? Food? I don't know what you want.

Dana: What about some flowers?

Salim: Flowers? Really?

Dana: Yes! Why not?

Salim: Aren't you too old for flowers?

Dana: Nobody is too old for flowers.

Salim: Fair point.

Dana: Flowers it is, then?

Salim: I'll think about it.

Dana: Come on… please…

Salim: Like I said, I'll think about it.

CHAPTER 64

Buy This Together

———

Samiha: Let's consider a new idea.

Joely: And what is it?

Samiha: Buying a new car.

Joely: Excellent thinking.

Samiha: But you should pay for it.

Joely: Me? Why me?

Samiha: You've got the eyes, you've got the beauty. You buy the new car.

Joely: That has nothing to do with anything.

Samiha: It has everything to do with it.

Joely: And what's that?

Samiha: The money.

Joely: I've got the money?

Samiha: Yes, you do.

Joely: No, I don't.

Samiha: At least you have more than me.

Joely: We can do this together.

Samiha: My dear friend, it's better if it's only you. Trust me.

Joely: Yeah, right.

Samiha: Yes, it is.

CHAPTER 65

Hold My Hand

———

Georgia: Break the glass.

Ricky: What?

Georgia: It's a tradition. Break the glass.

Ricky: No!

Georgia: Then hold my hand instead.

Ricky: Deal.

Georgia: Don't squeeze too hard. I'm sensitive.

Ricky: I won't.

Ricky holds Georgia's hand.

Georgia: I love you, Ricky.

Ricky: Me too.

Georgia: Say it… say the words.

Ricky: I do.

Georgia: You do?

Ricky: I do, yes. That's what I said.

Georgia: It means you love me?

Ricky: Yep!

Georgia gives Ricky a hug.

Ricky checks his watch while hugging Georgia.

CHAPTER 66

How About Another Shot?

———

Kelly: I like this bar.

Pia: What do you like about it?

Kelly: It's spacious.

Pia: And?

Kelly: It's a bar… I like everything about it.

Pia: That's it?

Kelly: What more do you want from it? It's not a spaceship.

Pia: I mean, the lighting could be a start.

Kelly: The lighting, the glasses, the seats. It's a bar… I like everything about it.

Pia: Good to know.

Kelly: Do you want another shot?

Pia: A shot of what?

Kelly: Tequila…

Pia: Sure, but I'm driving today.

Kelly: Yeah, yeah, who cares? IT'S A BAR…

Pia: It sure is…

CHAPTER 67

Be the Enemy

———

Melhem: Who are you?

Benjamin: A friend.

Melhem: Well, you don't look like one.

Benjamin: Well, I am, and I have everything to prove it.

Melhem: And what's that?

Benjamin: Clothes, food, culture… you name it.

Melhem: I'm still not convinced.

Benjamin: What do you want me to do? Get down on both knees and beg?

Melhem: Just leave me alone.

Benjamin: If I can't be your friend, I'll be something worse.

Melhem: And what's that?

Benjamin punches Melhem in the face.

CHAPTER 68

Call Her Up

———

Mustafa: Have you found her in any of the rooms?

Bridget: Nope.

Mustafa: Does she have a phone?

Bridget: She's only ten. I don't think so…

Mustafa: Call her. She has a phone.

Bridget: She has a phone? What?

Mustafa: Yes! It's almost the same number as yours, too.

Bridget: What?

Mustafa calls.

Bridget: It's ringing in her room.

Mustafa: Then where is she?

Bridget: Where the hell could she be?

CHAPTER 69

The Sun Is Hot

———

Mahdi: I've been tending the trees for hours now.

Sidney: You'd better stop.

Mahdi: Why?

Sidney: There's a heat wave coming.

Mahdi: Explain.

Sidney: There's nothing to explain… A heat wave… a hot sun and high temperatures.

Mahdi: I'm indestructible.

Sidney: No, you're not! You'll get a skin disease or something.

Mahdi: I won't!

Sidney: Yes, you will…

Mahdi: Well, who cares?

Sidney: I do…

Mahdi: You do?

Sidney: Jerk…

CHAPTER 70

I Cannot

———

Karen: Let's go out.

Kinda: Can't.

Karen: Why?

Kinda: Busy.

Karen: With what?

Kinda: Busy.

Karen: No, you're not. Just come with me.

Kinda: No.

Karen: Just do it!

Kinda: Can't!

Karen: Come on…

Kinda: No!

Karen: Oh my Lord!

Kinda: Bye!

Karen: Bite me!

CHAPTER 71

Shawarma

———

Lucian: I love this place.

Leila: Why? I hate it.

Lucian: Really? What's there to hate about it?

Leila: Everything.

Lucian: Like what?

Leila: The closest shawarma place is five blocks away.

Lucian: Come on…

Leila: It's a deal breaker, I'm telling you.

Lucian: No, it's not! What about the park, the beach, the malls…

Leila: Boring… No shawarma, no fun.

Lucian: Really?

Leila: I'm telling you. Deal breaker.

Lucian: Well, I never thought of it that way.

Leila: Good.

CHAPTER 72

It's Not the End of the World

———

Ibrahim: I've got an idea.

Jordan: What is it?

Ibrahim: We buy a Jet Ski.

Jordan: Nice!

Ibrahim: So you're with me on this idea, aren't you?

Jordan: Yeah, sure. What harm could it do?

Ibrahim: Unlike the motorcycle we had, right?

Jordan: It broke down, almost got us killed in an accident, and we could have ended up dead.

Ibrahim: What harm could it do?

Jordan: It's not the end of the world.

Ibrahim: Yeah!

Jordan: So, no Jet Ski.

Ibrahim: Yeah. No Jet Ski.

CHAPTER 73

Ask the Boss

———

Mariam: We've been waiting for hours now.

Chloe: What do you want us to do, beg to get in?

Mariam: We could try.

Chloe: I'd rather leave.

Yvonne: Me too.

Mariam: Okay, okay…

Chloe: You know what the best solution is?

Yvonne: What?

Chloe: Talk to the big guy.

Mariam: You mean God?

Chloe: No, not God! The big guy.

Yvonne: I know what you mean…

Chloe: You do?

Yvonne: Yes. The big guy, my uncle Valorous.

Chloe: NO!

Mariam: Who are you calling the big guy?

Chloe: The boss.

Yvonne: The boss?

Mariam: The boss?

Chloe: Yes! The boss.

CHAPTER 74

The Zoo

———

Dina: I like all kinds of animals.

Rahem: Like what?

Dina: All of them.

Rahem: Even the ones that fly?

Dina: Especially the ones that fly.

Rahem: You know what the most vicious animal out there is?

Dina: The tiger?

Rahem: No.

Dina: The killer whale?

Rahem: No.

Dina: A dinosaur…

Rahem: No.

Dina: I don't know. What is it?

Rahem: A human.

Dina: Oh, I forgot about that.

Rahem: Humans are the most dangerous animals out there.

Dina: They sure are.

Rahem: And we're among them. Remember that.

Dina: I will.

CHAPTER 75

Do You Know How to Change a Tire?

———

Brooke: Hi! Can you hear me?

Tina: Yes! I can hear you.

Brooke: I'm stuck in the middle of the street.

Tina: And? What seems to be the problem?

Brooke: I need someone to help me.

Tina: With changing your tire?

Brooke: Yes! Now stop being an imbecile and help me.

Tina: Hey! Hey! Language. No need to go that far.

Brooke: Well, you're getting on my nerves.

Tina: A change will happen, but not to your tire anytime soon.

Brooke: Then to what?

Tina: To your bad behavior!

Brooke: Well, fuck you!

Tina: Fuck you too!

CHAPTER 76

How Many Records Do You Have?

———

Veronica: I like summer.

Taty: Well, I like winter.

Veronica: Do you want to see my record collection?

Taty: Yeah, sure! Why not?

Veronica: It's hidden up in the attic.

Taty: Oh, really?

Veronica: Here, follow me…

Taty: Wow! You have so many records.

Veronica: I know, right? What do you want to listen to?

Taty: What about Michael Jackson?

Veronica: Sure… Anything else?

Taty: The Beatles.

Veronica: It's all here.

Taty: You're such a great friend.

Veronica: Thanks to you, Taty.

Taty: Thanks to me.

CHAPTER 77

The Game Is the Game

———

Nasser: Where are we going?

Mira: Home!

Nasser: Who told you to go this way?

Mira: Our friends. Why?

Nasser: You're so gullible.

Mira: No, I'm not!

Nasser: If they told you to jump in the ocean, would you jump in the ocean?

Mira: As a matter of fact, in certain situations, I would jump in the ocean if they told me to.

Nasser: Such an idiot!

Mira: Hey! Language… Why are you talking to me like that? We'll get there…

Nasser: Well, the game is the game.

Mira: What do you mean?

Nasser: The game is the game… What do you think I mean?

Mira: I don't know.

Nasser: Well, you sure don't!

CHAPTER 78

Crush Me Some Nuts

———

Fatima: Red or pink?

Fakih: What do you mean?

Fatima: I mean: red… or pink…

Fakih: Oh, you mean the dresses. Well, I think red.

Fatima: Well, I was thinking pink!

Fakih: Pink? Well, yeah, pink.

Fatima: Pink it is!

Fakih: Yay, pink it is.

Fatima: Do you want to buy some nuts on the way?

Fakih: Do you know how to crush nuts?

Fatima: You teach me… Besides, I like it when you crush nuts.

Fakih: I don't follow…

Fatima: You never will, honey.

Fakih: I sure won't.

Fatima: Red it is, then.

Fakih: Red. Yeah, red…

CHAPTER 79

Which Airport Again?

———

Roman: Where are we heading?

Luka: Home.

Roman: From this airport?

Luka: We're in transit to another airport.

Roman: Where?

Luka: Turkey.

Roman: How long are we staying?

Luka: A few hours.

Roman: Not much time to explore.

Luka: There sure isn't.

Roman: What do you want to do now?

Luka: I don't know. Wait.

Roman: Sounds good to me.

Luka: It sure does.

CHAPTER 80

Haircut

———

Abbas: I've been playing this game for so long.

Imad: You mean Clash?

Abbas: No! The candy one.

Imad: Oh, this one… It seems quite difficult once you reach the high levels.

Abbas: It sure is.

Imad: Do you want a harder game?

Abbas: No, thank you! What I need is a haircut.

Imad: Do you want me to do it?

Abbas: Are you good at this stuff?

Imad: I have a shop back home.

Abbas: A barbershop?

Imad: Yes, sir.

Abbas: Well, I trust you with my life, so I can trust you with my hair.

Imad: I won't let you down.

CHAPTER 81

Pedicure

———

Osman: Ever since I gained weight, I've been getting my nails done.

Ashraf: You mean a pedicure? I've been going since I was a little kid.

Osman: It sucks, doesn't it?

Ashraf: I enjoy it, even though I'm fat. I get a great experience out of it.

Osman: Like what?

Ashraf: I get to know all the ladies.

Osman: Oh, really…

Ashraf: They call me Big Show now.

Osman: Wow! Wow!

CHAPTER 82

Send Me a Text

———

Maya: Do you like texting?

Karim: No.

Maya: What about calling, then?

Karim: Not that either.

Maya: Texting and calling?

Karim: Neither, thanks.

Maya: Then what is it?

Karim: Talking.

Maya: Talking. Just talking?

Karim: Yes, in person.

Maya: And what about flirting? What's your take on that?

Karim: That's better done through talking too.

Maya: So it really is just talking.

Karim: Yes.

Maya: Have you ever considered dancing? People can say a lot through a dance.

Karim: Yes, that could work.

Maya: So dancing and talking are your two go-to moves.

Karim: You could say that.

Maya: Okay, one last thing.

Karim: Yes, what?

Maya: Sniffing?

Karim: What about it?

Maya: Does that fit your criteria too?

Karim: No.

Maya: Deal, then. Just dancing and talking.

Karim: Deal.

CHAPTER 83

Make It Obvious

———

Dania: You're going on stage today, right?

Lucas: Yes!

Dania: What will you be talking about?

Lucas: Receiving and broadcasting.

Dania: And?

Lucas: And what?

Dania: And I still don't know the opening.

Lucas: What opening?

Dania: The opening ceremony you're supposed to be part of. Don't you remember?

Lucas: Oh, right. That too.

Dania: Will you stay until the end?

Lucas: Depends.

Dania: Okay. What about after the ceremony?

Lucas: What about it?

Dania: Are you coming out with us?

Lucas: Yeah, sure.

Dania: Gates open at nine. Are you ready?

Lucas: Yes.

Dania: It's 8:28 exactly. Are you ready?

Lucas: Yes.

Dania: Do you have your mic?

Lucas: Yes.

Dania: Do you have notes, in case you forget something? Honestly, you don't need them, but do you have notes?

Lucas: Yes.

Dania: Are you feeling well?

Lucas: Yes. Can I please go now?

Dania: Go. And one more thing.

Lucas: What?

Dania: Make us proud.

CHAPTER 84

When Do You Go to the Bathroom?

———

Nadia: When do you go to the bathroom?

Ethan: Whenever.

Nadia: What do you mean, whenever?

Ethan: Whenever I feel like it.

Nadia: Don't you have a schedule?

Ethan: No.

Nadia: I have one.

Ethan: Good for you.

Nadia: Do you want to see it?

Ethan: No, thanks.

Nadia: I'll show you anyway. Look!

Ethan: Ooh, how nice. Now leave me alone.

Nadia: Wait, it goes like this: every two hours in the morning, then every three, then every four at night. Does that sound convincing?

Ethan: Not really, but as long as it works for you, great.

Nadia: Do you have any suggestions for how I could change it?

Ethan: No idea. Now, bye.

Nadia: Bye!

CHAPTER 85

Why Stop Here When You Can Reach There?

———

Malek: What are you doing, exactly?

Simon: Writing.

Malek: Writing what?

Simon: A script.

Malek: A script for what?

Simon: A script for a movie about the past, the present, and the future. How it might be possible, through a single film, to move through all three and still get every prediction right. Happy?

Malek: Write about me.

Simon: What?

Malek: Yes, write about me.

Simon: Who are you?

Malek: I'm your guide. Your protector through all these years. Why won't you write about me?

Simon: I'll think about it, okay? Just leave me alone.

Malek: You could still write about the past, the present, and the future.

Simon: How?

Malek: You'll figure it out. Just write about me, and you'll see.

Simon: No. You want this for your own benefit. Please, just leave me alone.

Malek: Just consider it, okay? I know people.

Simon: Yeah, sure.

Malek: Just…

CHAPTER 86

If I Write This, Will You Be Mad at Me?

———

Ryan: I slept with multiple people.

Hailey: And?

Ryan: None of them were you.

Hailey: And?

Ryan: Stop writing.

Hailey: I won't. And?

Ryan: Please, stop!

Hailey: And we're done. Anything else?

Ryan: I thought you loved me.

Hailey: I thought I loved you too.

Ryan: But?

Hailey: There are no buts here.

Ryan: There are always buts.

Hailey: Yes, but you were a liar.

Ryan: No, I wasn't. Do you have proof?

Hailey: I don't.

Ryan: Then I'm not a liar.

Hailey: True, in a sense.

Ryan: And?

Ryan leaves.

Hailey: Leave, then. I'm fine on my own anyway.

Silence.

Hailey: Oh. He actually left. He really, actually left.

About the Author

Jad is a twenty-four-year-old computer and communications engineer and web developer based in Beirut, Lebanon. By day, he builds software; in whatever hours are left over, he collects conversations—the weird ones, the amusing ones, the everyday ones that quietly turn into life lessons without warning.

He grew up with a fairly average late-nineties-and-two-thousands childhood, full of the kind of constant, casual, in-person human interaction that his generation took for granted. He has watched that kind of interaction grow rarer over the years, and harder to come by with certain people—which is part of what drew him to write a book built entirely out of talking.

Outside of engineering and writing, Jad produces short-form content under the handle @jad, aimed at putting smiles on people's faces, especially in the weirdest and most unexpected situations, and he writes about current events in Lebanon. *The 15-Minute Chats* is his first book.

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